

TRACK 1 · PRESENCE

QuietBridge

"It turns one overwhelmed voice note into the right kind of help – not necessarily a reply."

Host: EverSettled · Sponsors: ElevenLabs · Lovable

3:07 AM, and Maya can't sleep

The moment

Her mother died last night. Work is messaging. The bank wants documents. She hasn't slept.

The interface

One phone, one dark room, one thumb. Ask her more than one thing and she leaves.

"She wants the world reduced, not explained."

Cognitive overload, not information scarcity

People in crisis carry

Severe administrative burden, plus extreme mental fatigue, all at once.

What fails them

Companions that talk too much and add to the load. Software that demands everything now.

Empathy is a decision, not a script

"Empathy is not primarily what you say. It is how you decide what kind of help to give, and how much."

QuietBridge makes silence, burden triage, and escalation first-class actions, not response-styling.

Five care modes, combinable not exclusive

WITNESS

Acknowledge. Zero follow-up questions.

ORGANISE

Extract one action. Queue the rest.

QUIET

Minimal UI. Minimal or no speech.

SOFTEN

Emotional holding. No advice.

ESCALATE

Crisis mode. Routes to real help.

Three panels: Heard, Chose, Did

What I Heard

Mood declared via plain-language chips, never clinical words.

What I Chose

The visible care-state, and why. Not a black box.

What I Did

One action. Word-capped. Nothing else demanded tonight.

Chips: "There's too much" · "I feel nothing" · "It's hitting me" · "I'm scared about something" · "I'd rather not say"

The LLM perceives. Code decides.

The pre-built answer to "isn't this just prompt styling?"

Deterministic, not vibes

Mode selection, priority scoring, crisis first-pass, and check-in-vs-stay-quiet all run in code.

Enforced after generation

Word caps: QUIET 25 · WITNESS 35 · SOFTEN 45 · ORGANISE/ESCALATE 60. Speed: ESCALATE 0.80x · QUIET 0.85x · SOFTEN 0.90x.

Speech in, too: OpenAI `whisper-1` transcribes a spoken note before the router ever runs.

Crisis safety works with no network

The classifier runs first

Local 25-term, recall-biased lexicon. Returns before any network call. False positives are fine. False negatives are not.

The copy is disciplined

≤45 words. No moralising. Never "I'm just an AI." No euphemism: "died," never "journey."

999 / A&E

Unsafe right now.

NHS 111

Urgent, not immediate.

Samaritans 116 123

Someone to listen.

NOT BUILT

We rejected the camera, on purpose

The inference isn't sound

Barrett, Adolphs, Marsella, Martinez & Pollak (2019), *Emotional Expressions Reconsidered*. Facial movements don't reliably signal specific emotions across people and contexts. A grieving flat face and a bored flat face are the same face.

Wrong data class

Biometric-class data under UK GDPR, and squarely in the EU AI Act's line of fire.

Contradicts the thesis

A camera prompt before the first sentence is the loudest demand in the product.

Most fragile thing on stage

One failed permission dialog, and the demo is about a broken camera.

The rejection is a stronger answer than the feature.

The decision is real. Delivery is simulated.

What's real

The decision to check in or stay quiet is computed, recorded, and inspectable.

What's simulated

The actual delivery of a check-in: this build doesn't send one.

The seam: `check_in_decisions` is a drainable outbox with `due_at` + `delivery_state`. No routing or memory changes needed to make it real.

Time-Shift simulator: 3 stops, permanently labelled "Simulator – moves the clock, not real time."

The button reads "I can stay quiet now." One tap, no confirmation, 12-hour window. Screen reduces to: "I'll be here. Nothing until tomorrow."

Built for all four criteria

Originality

A third thing: a decision engine for care, not a companion or a rewrite filter.

Technical Execution

939 LOC. Deterministic router, local crisis lexicon, cache-backed voice, honest degradation.

Applicability

Recall-biased safety, word caps enforced in code. A front door, not a Sage competitor.

Fit to the Brief

Remembers, decides, acts, and restrains itself, all visible in the first 90 seconds.

One manageable next step

"I noticed this person is overwhelmed. So I chose not to perform empathy at them. I reduced the world to one manageable next step."